

University of Derby Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) Action Plan

Introduction

The University of Derby joined the Coalition on Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) in June 2023. In joining CoARA and signing the associated Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment the University signalled both internally and externally its willingness to continue to develop approaches for responsible research assessment to support excellent, impactful research. The Agreements [Principles](#) and associated [Commitments](#) reflect the direction in which the University is already progressing in terms of research assessment and the development of its research culture, as evidenced by the University being a signatory of the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment ([DORA](#)) and an early adopter of More Than Our Rank ([MTOR](#)).

The CoARA Action Plan therefore provides the opportunity for the University to reflect on and enhance areas of good practice, while also extending our consideration and practice to further embed the principles of responsible research assessment across the institution. The CoARA Action Plan and its implementation provides a means of giving focus particularly to aspects of the 'Principles' section of the University's Innovation and Research Strategy 2024-2029 and to the University's REF 2029 Strategy and approach. The specifics of the CoARA Action Plan will evolve as the implementation of these two Strategies progress, noting that they will also be influenced by external drivers, particularly the University REF Strategy as further guidance for REF 2029 becomes available.

This CoARA Action Plan was approved by the University's Academic Board in January 2025.

CoARA Commitment	Internal Driver	Action	Timeframe/ Deadlines	Responsibility
1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 PCE	Review and revise AP and P job descriptions to support career progression via the research, learnings and teaching, and professional practice routes	March 2025	Conferment T&F Group
		Review internal promotion (AP & P) procedures and associated guidance including that associated use of metrics	March 2025	Conferment T&F Group
		Use internal promotions guidance review as basis for discussions about reviewing the processes associated with recruitment, including the responsible use of metrics	AY 2024/2025	Conferment T&F Group
		Undertake EDI assessments and review relevant policies and statements in line with standard review periods	May 2025 Initial scoping of EDI assessment - Ongoing as policies and statements reviewed	PCE Principles WG
			2025-2026	

		Explore the opportunities for the recognition of different peoples' contributions to research associated with the University being a signatory of the Technicians Commitment and the implementation of CRediT Taxonomy part of the Research Publication and Open Access Policy		Policy/statement owners ORG and PCE Principles WG
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	Support focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF2029 and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance REF 2029	Development of Peer Review Policy Development of Peer Review procedures Peer review training/resources – to support new peer review policy and procedures Revision of responsible metric statement - incorporating new DORA indicators guidance	Jan 2025 (policy) 2025-2026 2025-2026 2025-2026	Peer Review WG Procedure owners Procedure owners ORG

3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF2029 and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Signatory of DORA Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 Institutional Open Research Statement which is currently in development	Assess correlation between FWCI, REF ratings (Mock REF) and CABS Journal Rankings - Initial assessment correlation undertaken - Ongoing assessment of correlation Review internal promotion metrics guidance Use internal promotions guidance review as basis for discussions about reviewing the processes associated with recruitment, including the responsible use of metrics Development of Peer Review policy Develop guidance to support researchers around venues for publication taking into account responsible assessment of journals / publishers	Dec 2024 Up to Jan 2029 March 2025 AY 2024/2025 Jan 2025 2025-2026	REF Steering Committee REF Steering Committee ORG and Conferment T&F Group Conferment T&F Group Peer Review WG ORG
--	---	---	--	--

4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Institutional Values Signatory of external 'benchmarks' (DORA and MTOR)	Collaborate with Marketing (internal and external comms) to ensure narrative around research assessment recognises significance of responsible research assessment	2025-2026	ORG
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	The specific resources being used to support this action plan are implied as part of the indication of the groups responsible for actions associated with the other CoARA Commitments			
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF2029 and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values /Policies REF 2029	Review internal promotion metrics guidance Use internal promotions guidance review as basis for discussions about reviewing the processes associated with recruitment, including the responsible use of metrics Define processes for specific peer review processes (e.g. peer review of external research grant	March 2025 AY 24- 25 2025-2026	Conferment T&F Group and ORG Conferment T&F Group Procedure Owners

		applications) informed by Peer Review Policy		
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029	Develop an institutional Open Research Statement – provide a focus for developing an institutional linchpin and narrative Ensure example criteria for any internal funding opportunities and associated procedures are fair and transparent	Jan 2025 2025-2026	ORG Funding ‘owners’
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	REF 2029	Support and contribute to CoARA National Chapter As an OR4 Project Case Study institution share institutional learning and gain from the experiences of other OR4 institutions. Share learning & gain from the experiences of the LIBER Open	Ongoing 2024-2027 Ongoing	Institutional CoARA Representatives ORG Library Services

		Research Europe Librarian Advisory Group.		
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values REF 2029	Annual report on progress against CoARA Action Plan and Action Plan update to UIRC Publish UoD CoARA Action Plan on UoD and CoARA Websites	Annually at Sept meeting March 2025	ORG ORG
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 External funding agencies	Establish Research Data Management Working Group	January 2025	



Alternative presentation of Action Plan, based on Actions

CoARA Commitments

1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research.
2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators
3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index
4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in the research assessment
5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition
9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research

Action	CoARA Commitment	Internal Driver	Timeframe/ Deadlines	Responsibility
Review AP and P job descriptions for each of the career routes (research, learning and teaching and professional practice).	1	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029	March 2025	Conferment T&F Group
Review internal promotion use of metrics guidance	1, 3, 6	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029	March 2025	Conferment T&F Group
Use internal promotions guidance review as basis for discussions about reviewing the processes associated with recruitment, including the responsible use of metrics	1, 3, 6	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029	AY 2024-2025	Conferment T&F Group
Undertake EDI assessments on relevant policies and statements	1	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 PCE	Initial scoping of EDI assessment May 2025. Then ongoing as Policies and Statements reviewed	PCE Principles WG Policy/Statement owners
Explore the opportunities for the recognition of different peoples' contributions to research associated with the	1	Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 PCE	2025-2026	ORG and PCE Principles WG

University being a signatory of the Technicians Commitment and the implementation of CRedit Taxonomy part of the Research Publication and Open Access Policy				
Development of Peer Review Policy	2, 3, 6	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance REF 2029	Jan 2025 (Policy)	Peer Review WG
Development of Peer Review procedures informed by the Peer Review Policy	2, 3, 6	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance REF 2029	2025-2026	Procedure owners
Peer review training/resources – to support new peer review policy and procedures	2	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance REF 2029	2025-2026	Procedure owners

Revision of responsible metric statement - incorporating new DORA indicators guidance	2	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance REF 2029	2025-2026	ORG
Assess correlation between FWCI, REF ratings (Mock REF) and CABS Journal Rankings - Initial assessment of correlation undertaken (Dec 2024) - Ongoing assessment of correlation up to submission of REF 2029	3	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Signatory of DORA Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 Institutional Open Research Statement which is currently in development	Dec 2024 Up to Jan 2029	REF Steering Committee REF Steering Committee
Develop guidance to support researchers around venues for publication taking into account responsible assessment of journals / publishers	3	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Signatory of DORA	2025-2026	ORG

		Institutional Values / Policies REF 2029 Institutional Open Research Statement which is currently in development		
Work with Marketing (internal and external comms) to ensure narrative around research assessment recognises significance of responsible research assessment	4	Institutional Values Signatory of external 'benchmarks' (DORA and MTOR)	2025-2026	ORG
Develop an institutional Open Research Statement – provide a focus for developing an institutional linchpin and narrative	7	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance	January 2025	ORG
Ensure example criteria for any internal funding opportunities and associated procedures are fair and transparent	7	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance	2025-2026	Funding 'owners'
Support and contribute to CoARA National Chapter	8	REF 2029	Ongoing	Institutional CoARA Representatives

As an OR4 Project Case Study institution share institutional learning and gain from the experiences of other OR4 institutions.	8	REF 2029	2024-2027	ORG
Share learning & gain from the experiences of the LIBER Open Research Europe Librarian Advisory Group.	8	REF 2029	Ongoing	Library Services
Annual report on progress against CoARA Action Plan and Action Plan update to UIRC (September meeting)	9	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values REF 2029	Annually at Sept meeting	ORG
Publish UoD CoARA Action Plan on UoD and CoARA Websites	9	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance Institutional Values REF 2029	March 2025	ORG
Establish Research Data Management Working Group	10	Focus on research quality in line with the institutional REF	January 2025	

		and I&R strategies, and REF criteria for quality of rigour, originality and significance		
		Institutional Values / Policies		
		REF 2029 External funding agencies		

Glossary

AP and P	Associate Professor and Professor
CABS Journal Ranking	Chartered Association of Business Schools' Journal Ranking
CRedit Taxonomy	Contributor Role Taxonomy
DORA	San Fransisco Declaration on Research Assessment
EDI	Equality, Diversity and Inclusion
FWCI	Field Weighted Citation Index
I&R	Innovation & Research
ORG	Open Research Group
REF 2029	Research Excellence Framework 2029
REF 2029 PCE	Research Excellence Framework 2029 People, Culture and Environment statement
T&F	Task & Finish
UIRC	University Innovation and Research Committee
UoD	University of Derby
UPC	University Professorial Council
WG	Working Group